# Minding the World

**Ruchira Kamboj,** *59*
*India's Permanent Representative to the UN*

**HER LARGEST CHALLENGES, SAYS RUCHIRA KAMBOJ,** the first woman to become India's Permanent Representative to the United Nations, come from the high standards that she has set for herself since childhood. An all-India topper in the 1987 Civil Services batch, Ruchira says that she has consistently striven to meet and surpass her own expectations. "From my early days as a young officer to my role as an ambassador, my journey has been driven by a commitment to excel," she says.

Ruchira's diplomatic odyssey commenced in Paris in 1989, where she served as the third secretary at the Indian Embassy in France until 1991. From 1996 to 1999, she was first secretary (economic and commercial) at the Indian High Commission in Mauritius. In 2002, she joined India's Permanent Mission to the UN as a counsellor, and by 2014, she was part of the G-4 team that played a pivotal role in the reform and expansion of the UN Security Council.

The year 2014 was a notable one. She directed the swearing-in ceremony of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, which saw eminent leaders from SAARC countries and Mauritius. And as India's ambassador to UNESCO in Paris, she championed significant cultural initiatives for India.

**ACCOMPLISHMENT**

**Ruchira Kamboj, India's first woman ambassador to the UN, has held a wide variety of roles during her decades-long diplomatic career**

"Each assignment was a new frontier, laden with its own set of challenges. There is no substitute for hard work. There is a lot of prep depending upon the assignment—you have to prepare yourself, look at the issue from various angles. This is not always seen from the outside," she says.

For Ruchira, being part of the foreign service is the realisation of a dream. However, she admits that maintaining a work-life balance is challenging in a role that demands constant dedication and sacrifice. "It's a 24/7 commitment, but the rewards are beyond measure," she says.

Ruchira, who is married to businessman Diwakar Kamboj and has a daughter, cherishes the small moments of joy and solitude amidst her busy schedule. ■

***–Sonali Acharjee***



**MAGIC POTION**

**"Hard work is the key to unlocking opportunities. Stay dedicated, and luck will follow"**

**NATURE LOVER**
**In her leisure time, Kamboj finds solace in the outdoors, amidst the company of birds and animals**